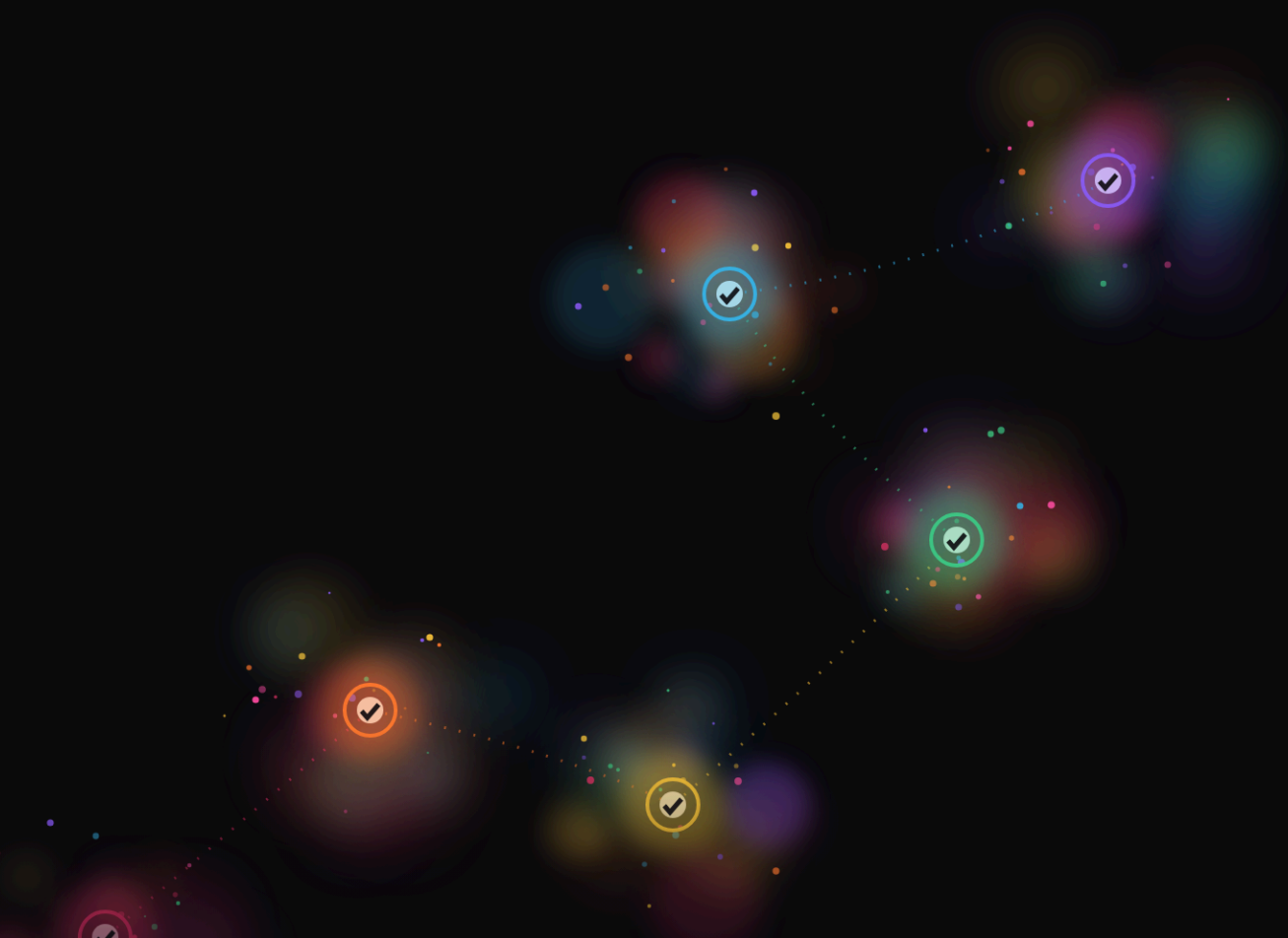


FREE TOOL · FROM **THE ARTIST OPERATOR** BY JAMIL APOSTOL



THE TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST

Five phases, twenty-five boxes,
zero forgotten load-ins.

HOW TO USE THIS

A tour is not a trip; it is a project with a budget, a schedule, and about two hundred small decisions that all want to be made at the last minute. This checklist front-loads them. **Five phases, five boxes each.** Work top to bottom; every box is written to be checked once, in writing, so nothing lives in your head or in a group chat.

The deeper system behind this page is Chapter 12 of **THE ARTIST OPERATOR** — the DISTRIBUTE job — and the day-sheet and settlement discipline comes from the touring chapters. If a box makes you realize you have no system for it at all, that is the box doing its job.

Print this. Put it on the wall where the routing map is. A checklist on a screen is a suggestion; a checklist on a wall with pen marks on it is an operation.

- 1** **12–16 WEEKS OUT** Route & anchor
- 2** **8–12 WEEKS OUT** Book & confirm
- 3** **4–8 WEEKS OUT** Announce & advance
- 4** **TOUR WEEK & ON THE ROAD** Run the machine
- 5** **THE WEEK AFTER** Close the loop

“Hope is not a plan, and vibes are not a calendar.”

THE ARTIST OPERATOR

PHASE 1 · 12–16 WEEKS OUT

ROUTE & ANCHOR

- ☐ Pick the anchor dates first: the one or two shows that justify the trip (a festival slot, a strong market, a guarantee). Route everything else around them.
- ☐ Draw the route on an actual map before you send a single email. Dead days cost money; backtracking costs more.
- ☐ Set the tour budget ceiling: total costs you will not exceed, written down, before romance sets in.
- ☐ Decide the lineup and confirm availability in writing — including the fallback if someone drops.
- ☐ Open a tour sheet (one spreadsheet or one Headline pipeline): every prospect venue, contact, status, money.

NOTES FOR THIS PHASE

“Route everything around the anchor, not around the ego.”

TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST · PHASE 1

PHASE 2 · 8-12 WEEKS OUT

BOOK & CONFIRM

- ☐ Send holds to venues in every routed market — three prospects per open night, tracked, never from memory.
- ☐ Confirm each show in writing: date, load-in, set length, money, lodging, backline. A text thread is not a contract.
- ☐ Book lodging the same week a show confirms, while the calendar still has options.
- ☐ Announce nothing until the routing is locked. A moved date after the announce costs trust you cannot buy back.
- ☐ Order merch now: reprints take longer than you think, and the tour without merch is a tour at half revenue.

NOTES FOR THIS PHASE

"A show is booked when the money and the date are in writing. Not before."

TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST · PHASE 2

PHASE 3 · 4–8 WEEKS OUT

ANNOUNCE & ADVANCE

- ☐ Announce the tour to your direct line first — email before socials, always. The people who gave you their address get the news first.
- ☐ Build one promo asset per show for the venue and local promoter to use; make their job effortless.
- ☐ Advance every show: day-of contact, parking, settlement method, merch cut, set times. Write the answers into the day sheet.
- ☐ Pitch local press, radio, and playlists in each market — four weeks out is when they actually book coverage.
- ☐ Check the van, the gear, the insurance, the border paperwork if there is one. Boring reads now beat disasters later.

NOTES FOR THIS PHASE

“Your direct line hears it first. Every time.”

TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST · PHASE 3

PHASE 4 · TOUR WEEK & ON THE ROAD

RUN THE MACHINE

- ☐ Print or load the day sheets: one page per day, everything anyone needs to know, no group-chat archaeology.
- ☐ Count merch in and out every single night, per item. The count is the pay.
- ☐ Capture as you go: photos, one line in the tour log per night, emails collected at the merch table.
- ☐ Settle every show before you leave the building, and photograph the settlement sheet.
- ☐ Protect the humans: sleep, food, one honest check-in per week. The tour is only as strong as the people in the van.

NOTES FOR THIS PHASE

“The count is the pay. Count it.”

TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST · PHASE 4

CLOSE THE LOOP

- ☐ Reconcile the tour against the budget within seven days, while receipts still exist and memory still works.
- ☐ Send thank-yous: every promoter, host, engineer, and opener, by name. This is next year's routing.
- ☐ Email the new signups from the merch table within a week, while they still remember the night.
- ☐ Write the debrief: what made money, what lost money, which rooms want you back, what you will never do again.
- ☐ Put the next anchor date on the calendar. A tour that ends without the next one scheduled is a full stop, not a loop.

NOTES FOR THIS PHASE

“The tour is not over until the debrief is written and the next anchor is on the calendar.”

TOUR PLANNING CHECKLIST · PHASE 5

GO FURTHER

This checklist is a free tool from **THE ARTIST OPERATOR: How Musicians Win in the Age of AI, and Why the Future Still Belongs to Humans** by Jamil Apostol. The book turns each of these boxes into a system: the Six Jobs, the day-sheet discipline, the weekly loop that keeps a career moving between tours.

When the checklist outgrows paper, **Headline.world** is being built for exactly this: booking pipeline, tour routing, day sheets, merch counts, settlement records, and the fan list from the merch table, in one place. The paid packs go deeper — **The Six Jobs Audit** finds the weak department before the tour exposes it, and **The Operator's Week** keeps the loop turning when you get home.



HEADLINE.WORLD

Book it. Run it. Own it.

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